Soon after we signed the contract in 1991, this process had begun. Soon after the meeting with Dunayev, we advanced the milestones of the contract so that much of the hardware and blueprints, estimated to fill the cargo holds of more than three flights, were formally ours though we could not get them to India soon. Bill Clinton as the US President was not as hawkish towards India as was his predecessor Bush, but the system was something even Presidents could not change.

American spies were all over Russia, trying to sniff out everything related to the India-Russia deal. Washington had reasons to believe that despite the sanctions, and the original contract being annulled, Glavkosmos may transfer the technology to ISRO. What they did not know, however, was that some of it had already happened, at least on paper. We had advanced the milestones and, technically speaking, India had owned some of the drawings and materials though it had not taken possession of. Then we signed the second contract in January 1994, while the cargo was still in Russia.

At our side, the Ministry of External Affairs had given instructions to allow ISRO to take delivery of the cargo from any Indian airport without customs inspection. This did not go down well with some Customs officers who thought it their birthright to rummage through any container that reached the Indian airports.

At the Trivandrum airport, some of them tried citing rules and insisted on inspecting the cargo. I told them touch the ISRO cargo at their own peril. If anyone found the government instructions overbearing, I suggested they take up their case with the PMO or the MEA. When they could not meddle with the cargo, they tried to spread rumours about a racket that is smuggling cavier and vodka from Moscow!

A big disappointment for us was Air India. Despite the import having clearance from the highest level, the national carrier refused to take the cargo fearing loss of business if the Americans came to know of it. Air India was making some money out of its trans-Atlantic flights, and without landing rights in the US, ‘the Maharaja’ would find the going tough. When